Nevertheless, far from pinpointing an exact chronological or geographical point of origin per se for the Shansabanis – something that is not possible given the current state of knowledge – this chapter underscores the fact that the origins of many protagonists throughout history, particularly those with non-elite beginnings, remain undocumented and ultimately unrecoverable.[8] Their ethnogeneses, ensuing either from the protagonists' own invention or *a posteriori* piecing together by modern academics (as is the case here and, really, in all modern studies), are nothing more nor less than the synthesized results of the needs and conventions of the moment of writing inhabited by the court chronicler or modern investigator. The resulting narrative may withstand sustained scrutiny or it may not, depending on further recovery of information on the region and its inhabitants over time. An exploration of the Shansabanis' pre-imperial history essentially provides a case study of the intriguing process by which an obscure kinship-based group, practicing seasonal transhumance and/or some form of nomadism, underwent a seemingly sudden rise to regional and transregional prominence.

Indeed, unearthing a plausible, *non*-mythical early history of the Shansabanis, and the way of life of their forebears during the eleventh through the first half of the twelfth centuries is more than a "seductive necessity": it serves one of the fundamental aims of this project, namely, "essay[ing] non-sectarian histories of conquest … conflict," and cultural transformation.[9] The search for Shansabani beginnings helps us to confront the complexities inherent in "Islam," its many cultural, political, *and* religious implications, as well as the impetuses for conversion and/or public confessionalism. Rather than a general explication of historical adoptions of Islam, the early Shansabanis provide one concrete iteration of what were multifarious and contingent processes across historical Eurasia, each deserving of close analysis in its own right.[10]

The general paucity of textual sources, and the literary conventions reigning in those that do exist,[11] urge the investigator to turn to other potential repositories of information, wherein there may be indications of the Shansabanis' pre-imperial beginnings. Among the notable alternative avenues for gleaning clues are the available numismatic data[12] and – the focus here – the architectural remains scattered throughout Ghur (e.g. Figures 2.1, 2.5–2.10, 2.13–2.16). With the exceptions of the Saghar *minar* (Figure 2.17) and probable summer "capital" of Jam-Firuzkuh (Figure 2.2) – discussed further in the current and following chapters – the vast majority of historical Ghur's built environment can be characterized as one of monumental decadence: the architectural landscape of central through southern Ghur consisted of pre-existing square or round multi-story towers, fortified enclosures of varying sizes on plains and promontories, and possibly interconnected lookout structures along the principal long-distance routes of travel (Figures 2.5–2.8).